Topic: Bangladesh Social Structure and Social Stratification: Group. Role and Status, Class, Prestige & Power, Social Mobility.

Basic Concept of Social Structure, Stratification and Mobility

Social Structure

- The term '**structure'** refers to the way the parts of anything relate to one another. *Social structure refers to the relationships between the units of a group or society.*
- The social structure includes kinship, religion, economics, politics, and other institutions, as well as the norms, values, and social roles of society's members. The development of social structure in any society is historically conditioned.
- **Building blocks of social structure:** Statuses, Roles, Social Institutions
- **Social Status** refers to the socially defined position of a person within a large group or society, from the lowest to the highest.
- There are two types of statuses

1. **Ascribed status**: Positions involuntarily acquired through birth. Being a female. A prince/princess, a son, an American.
2. **Achieved Status**: Positions acquired through personal efforts. Being an architect, a doctor, or a social worker.

Social Structure

Roles refer to the expected behavior patterns, obligations, and privileges associated with a particular social status. Many expectations regarding a person's behavior are associated with each role or social position. Social roles contribute to a society's stability by enabling members to anticipate the behavior of others and to pattern their actions accordingly.

Social Roles: Social roles are the components of social structure and interaction. Role and Status are two concepts that are closely intertwined. A social role is a set of expectations that individuals within a social position or status are expected to fulfill.

Social Structure

- **Social Institutions**: A social institution is an interrelated system of social roles and norms organized around satisfying an essential social need and social function. Some basic needs include providing physical and emotional support, transmitting knowledge, producing goods and services, maintaining social control, etc.

The family, religion, law, politics, economics, education, science, medicine, and the military are all social institutions. Each institution has its own set of roles, values, and norms that set limits and provide guidelines for behavior. In industrial societies, social institutions are more formal, whereas they are quite informal in tribal societies.

Social Structure

Finally, we can consider social structure to function on three societal levels: macro, meso, and micro.

Social Structure: The Macro Level of Society

Sociologists use "social structure," which typically refers to macro-level social forces, including social institutions and patterns of institutionalized relationships.

These are understood as distinct institutions that are interrelated and interdependent and together help compose a society's overarching social structure.

These institutions organize our social relationships with others and create patterns of social relations when viewed on a large scale. For example, the institution of the family organizes people into distinct social relationships and roles, including mother, father, son, daughter, husband, wife, and others. There is typically a hierarchy to these relationships, which results in a power differential. The same goes for religion, education, law, and politics.

Social Structure

- **Social Networks: The Meso-Level Manifestation of Social Structure**

Sociologists see social structure at the "meso" level—between the macro and micro levels—in the social networks organized by the social institutions and institutionalized social relationships. For example, systemic racism fosters, resulting in some racially homogenous networks.

Our social networks also reflect social stratification, where class differences, educational attainment, and wealth levels influence social relations among individuals. In turn, social networks act as structuring forces by shaping the kinds of opportunities that may or may not be available to us and by fostering behavioral and interactional norms that influence our life course and outcomes.

Social Structure

- **Social Interaction**: Social Structure at the Micro Level of Everyday Life

Social structure manifests at the micro level in our everyday interactions through norms and customs. We can see it present in the way patterned institutionalized relationships shape our interactions within certain institutions like family and education, and it is present in the way institutionalized ideas about race, gender, and sexuality shape what we expect from others, how we hope to be seen by them, and how we interact together.

Social Structure

- Types of Societies

  Hunting and Gathering Societies: The oldest and simplest type of society is the ‘hunting and gathering’ society. It is small, nomadic, and lacks a desire to acquire wealth. Family and kinship are the only defined institutions. There is no political institute. There is limited or no division of labor. There is a constant need to face danger. and simple religious beliefs.

  Pastoral Societies: Around 10 to 12 thousand years ago, some hunting and gathering groups began to adopt a new subsistence strategy based on domesticating herds of animals. This strategy had relatively large characteristics, with pastoralism as a better productive strategy, the beginning of a new plan, and nomadism coupled with trading, pastoralism, the development of religious belief, and herding technology leading to several changes.

  Horticulture Societies: This society is associated with the elementary discovery that plants can be grown from seeds. Horticulture societies first existed in the Middle East about 4000 BC and spread to China and Europe; later, they reached Sub-Saharan Africa. Characteristics of horticulture societies are the domestication of plants, slash-and-burn technology, horticulturists being better settled than pastoralists, the relatively more complex division of labor, the emergence of political institutions, the creation of relatively elaborate cultural artifacts, etc.

Social Structure

- **Industrial Societies**: The industrial mode of production began in England about 250 years ago. It became a very successful one and has spread all over the world. Characteristics of industrial societies are associated with the Industrial Revolution and industrialization, technology initiating profound and rapid social change, larger societies with huge populations, large-scale division of labor, losing the importance of family and kinship, religion losing its hold over the people, increasing importance of science and education, increasing important role of the state, widening gap between the rich and the poor.
- **Post-industrial societies**: Technology that supports an information-based economy. Production focuses on computers and other electronic devices that create, process, store, and apply information. People in post-industrial societies work on honing information--based skills for work involving computers and other high-technology communication. In this society, power lies in information.

Stratification

Stratification

- ***Social stratification*** refers to a system by which categories of people in society are ranke in a hierarchy.
- **Characteristics of Social Stratification**

- According to M.M. Tumin, the main attributes of stratification are as follows:

1. **It is Social**: Stratification is social because it does not represent biologically caused inequalit Indeed, such factors as strength, intelligence, age, and sex can often serve as the basis on wh statuses and strata are distinguished. Biological traits do not determine social superiority a inferiority until they are socially recognized and given importance.
2. **It is Ancient**: According to archeological and historical records, stratification was present ev in the small wandering band. Age and sex are the main criteria of stratification then. Wom and children are probably the dominant rules of order.
3. **It is Universal**: The stratification system is a worldwide phenomenon. Difference between rich and poor, haves and haves not.
4. **It is in the diverse form**: The stratification system has never been uniform in all societies.
5. **It is consequential:** The stratification system has its consequences. The most important, m

Principle Types of Social Stratification

- **Caste, Estate and Social Class**

Caste: A caste system is a form of social stratification based on ascription. The word ‘caste’ is derived from the Spanish term ‘caste,’ meaning ‘breed,’ ‘strain,’ or a complex of hereditary qualities. It represents a logical extreme, approaching the ideal type of inflexible order. This peculiar social stratification is predominantly found in India and neighboring regions. Three main stages in the evolution of caste can be identified in the Indian Subcontinent: i. Caste in Ancient Times: The period up to 1100 AD, which includes the Vedic Age, the Post-Vedic Age, and the Puranic Age. ii. Caste in the Medieval Age: The period between 1100 AD and 1757 AD mainly encompasses the age of Muslim rule in India. iii. Caste in the Modern Age: The period after 1757 AD includes the pre-independence British period and the time after independence. In this context, caste stratification refers to the ‘Chaturvarna’ system. According to the ‘Chaturvarna’ doctrine, Hindu society was divided into four main varnas: the Brahmins, the Kashrtiyas, the Vaishyas, and the Sudras. The central caste division was between Brahmins and non-Brahmins, with the latter being a mixture of different sub-castes that developed through uncontrolled interactions among various castes. Some believe that local Brahmans were not familiar with the Vedas, and Kaibarta Brahmans from Northern India migrated here to serve as priests. The non-Brahman sub-castes were generally divided into three hierarchical levels, within which there were as many as forty-one professional caste groups, including chandal, swarnakar, and tanti, among others.

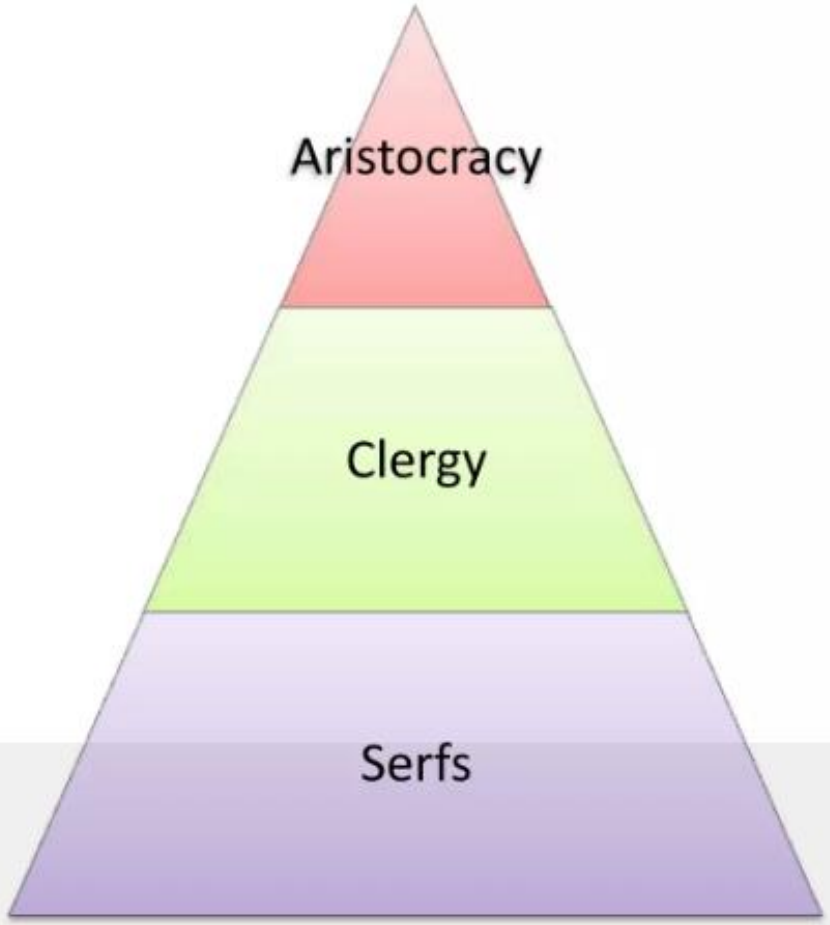
Caste system in Muslim society

- The Muslim conquest mainly contributed to the spread of Islam in Bengal. The new faith reached its peak in East Bengal, where Buddhism was the dominant religion until then.
- During the 19th century, Muslims of India, following the manner of the Hindus, fancifully divided themselves into four classes: Syeds, Sheiks, Mughals, and Pathans. The scholars, however, identified three broad categories.
- First, the Ashraf, or upper class, which included all undoubted descendants of foreign Muslims (Arabs, Persians, Afghans, and others), as well as converts from the higher Hindu castes.
- Second, the *Ajlaf* or ordinary people, which included functional groups such as *tanti*, *dhunari*, *kalu*, *napit*, and *darji*.
- In some places, a third class existed, called *Arzal*, which was the lowest of all social groups. This class included the Halalkhor, Lalbeghi, Abdal, and Bediya people, who were not allowed to enter mosques or public burial grounds and with whom other Muslims would not normally associate.

Principle Types of Social Stratification

- **Estate**: The term ‘Estate’ denotes European social stratification during the Middle Ages.
- This system originated in the ancient Roman Empire and persisted in Europe until quite recently.
- The United Kingdom's agricultural past, with its deep historical roots, was founded on a caste-like estate system.
- The estate system comprised three main divisions: **the clergy, the nobility, commoners, and ordinary people.**

Estate Systems



- Characterizes the status hierarchies found in Europe prior to capitalism.
- Membership in the Church (clergy) was not based on ascribed characteristics.
- However, highest rankings within clergy come from first estate (aristocracy).
- Like the caste system, position in an estate system is determined at birth. Contact is permitted, but generally impersonal.

Class System?



Class System

Class is based on socio-economic status.



Social Class System in Bangladesh [Muslim Society]

- Until the Partition of British India in 1947, Hindus controlled about 80 percent of all significant rural holdings, urban real estate, and government jobs in East Bengal and dominated finance, commerce, and the professions.
- After the partition in 1947, she soon came to be dominated by a West Pakistani-based elite whose members were favored by the government both directly and indirectly.

Class System in Bangladesh [Muslim Society]

- Soon after independence in 1971, the ill-prepared Bangladeshi elite moved into the areas vacated by West Pakistanis. Except for members of small non-Bengali caste-like Muslim groups known as "trading communities," Bangladeshi Muslims almost immediately established control over all small- and medium-sized industrial and commercial enterprises.
- However, traditional Muslim class distinctions had little importance in Bangladesh. The proscription against marriage between individuals of high-born and low-born families, once an indicator of the social gap between the two groups, had long ago disappeared; most matrimonial alliances were based on wealth and power and not on the ties of family distinction.

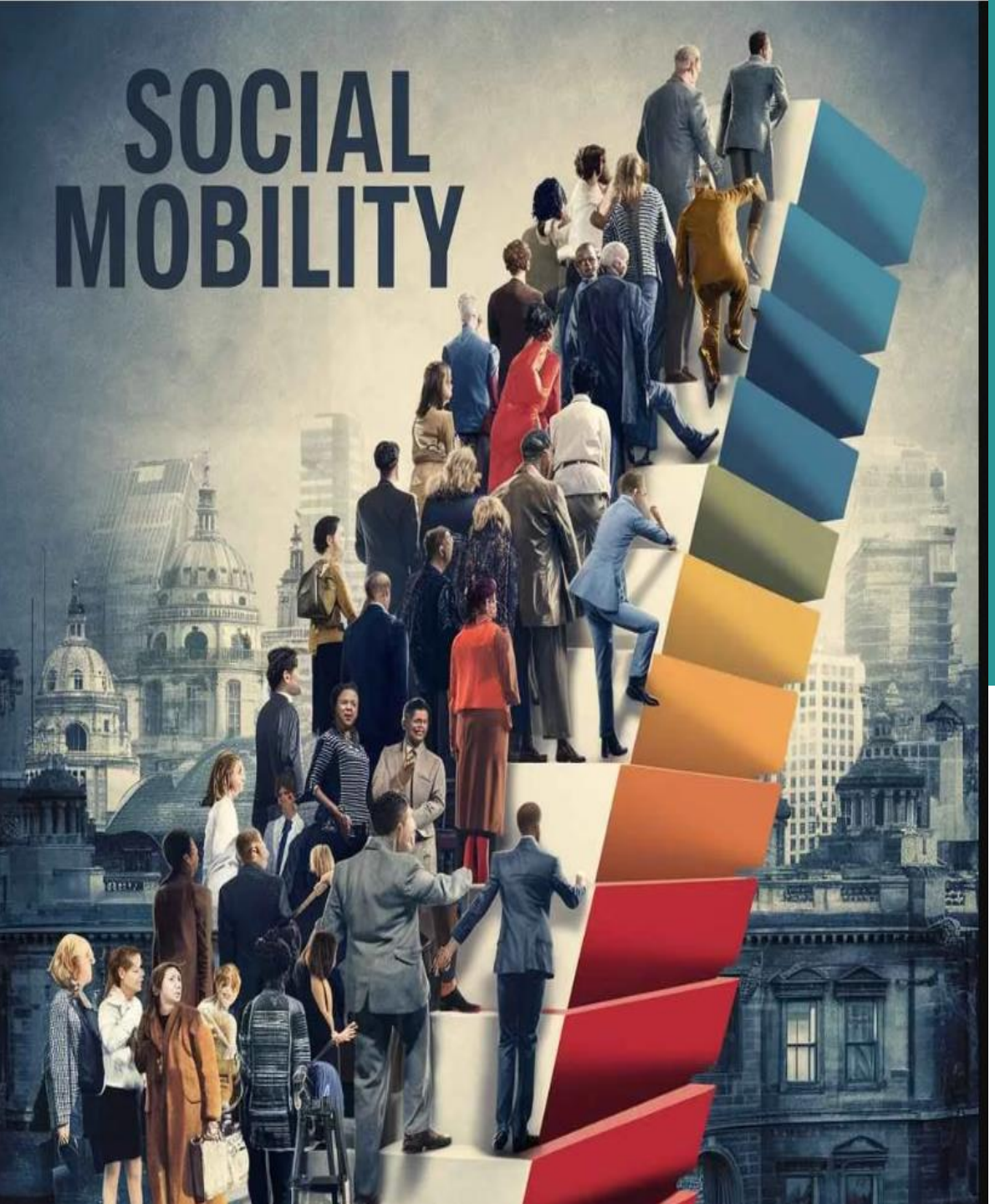
Class System in Bangladesh

- Bangladesh has **three major classes**: **the upper class, the middle class, and the lower class**. “Based on wealth criterion, the middle class can be divided at least into three categories -- lower middle class, mid-middle class, and upper-middle class; each type of middle-class people has their characteristics, status, and lifestyle. He also mentioned that the country's emerging middle class has immense potential to help accelerate industrialization.
- Although Hindu society is formally stratified into caste categories, caste did not figure prominently in the Bangladeshi Hindu community. Bangladeshi Hindus seemed to have become part of the mainstream culture without surrendering their religious and cultural distinctions.

- Social Mobility

Social Mobility

- Social mobility is related to stratification but it different from social stratification which refers to the hierarchical arrangement of society.
- In contrast, social mobility is t**he ability of individuals to change their position within that hierarchy**.
- The extent of social mobility in a society depends on its stratification system, which can be ascription-based and achievement-based.
- In an ascription-based stratification system, a person's class is determined by the characteristics they are born with, resulting in what is known as a closed society.
- In this context, social mobility is limited because individuals cannot control their birth circumstances. Conversely, in an achievement-based stratification system, a person's rank is determined by their accomplishments, characterizing an open society.


SOCIAL
MOBILITY



Social Mobility

- In such societies, individuals can ascend the social ladder through inherent talents or by acquiring skills. Based on this ability, social mobility can take various forms, including

  i. horizontal, ii. vertical, iii. intergenerational, iv. intra-generational, and v. structural.

i. **Horizontal Mobility**: This refers to changing an individual or group's occupational position or role without involving any change in its position in the social hierarchy.

ii. **Vertical Mobility**: This refers to changes in an individual's or group's position within the social hierarchy.

HORIZONTAL MOBILITY

Horizontal mobility takes place when someone moves from one job or occupational position to another, without their social standing changing.

DEFINITION

"Horizontal mobility is the process of making changes in the same status level while vertical mobility is the process of changing from one state to another either to a higher or lower level."

(Reddy, Reddy, & Naik, 2023, p. 300)

EXAMPLE

- **Changing organizations:** A student working part-time at Burger King is starting to work full-time at Mcdonalds. Despite an increase in working hours, this is horizontal mobility since the position is relative.
- **Transitioning to online work:** A language teacher in a private school quitting their job to start working as an online tutor.

VERTICAL MOBILITY

"Vertical mobility means movement up or down the socio-economic scale. Those who gain in property, income or status are said to be upwardly mobile ... whie those who move in the opposite direction are downwardly mobile." (Giddens & Griffiths, 2006, p. 328)

DEFINITION

Vertical mobility refers to the social transition between jobs and positions that have different standings in the social hierarchy.

An increase is known as upward mobility, while a decrease is referred to as downward mobility.

EXAMPLE

Changing organizations: A student working part-time at Burger King is starting to work full-time at Mcdonalds. Despite an increase in working hours, this is horizontal mobility since the position is relative.

Social Mobility

• iii. **Intergenerational Mobility**: Time factor is an essential element in social mobility. Based on the time factor involved in social mobility, there is another type of inter-generational mobility. It is a change in status from that which a child began within the parents and household to that of the child upon reaching adulthood. It refers to a change in the status of family members from one generation to the next. For example, a farmer's son becomes an officer. It is essential because the amount of this mobility in society tells us to what extent inequalities are passed on from one generation to the next. If there is very little inter-generational mobility, inequality is deeply built into society, for people's life chances are determined at birth. When there is mobility, people can achieve new statuses through their efforts, regardless of the circumstances of their birth.

• **Iv. Intragenerational Mobility:** Mobility that occurs in personal terms within the lifespan of the same person is called intra-generational mobility. It refers to the advancement in one's social level during one's lifetime. It may also be understood as a change in social status that occurs within a person's adult career. For example, a person working as a supervisor in a factory may become its assistant manager after getting a promotion.

Social Mobility

- V. Structural mobility: Structural mobility is a kind of vertical mobility. Structural mobility refers to mobility brought about by changes in the stratification hierarchy.
- It is a vertical movement of a specific group, class, or occupation relative to others in the stratification system. It is a type of forced mobility, for it takes place because of the structural changes and not because of individual attempts.
- For example, historical circumstances or labor market changes may lead to the rise or decline of an occupational group within the social hierarchy. An influx of immigrants may also alter class alignments -especially if the new arrivals are disproportionately highly skilled or unskilled.

Social Mobility

- **Social Mobility in Bangladesh**

The social system in Bangladesh is quite open. While family and kinship remain central to social life, class mobility is significantly influenced by an individual's qualities and achieved status, such as education, training, knowledge, and skills. Historically, family background has played a significant role in securing jobs across various sectors, particularly in the government. However, with modernization and industrialization, skill-based meritocracy has supplanted traditional social systems, rendering pure meritocracy no longer prevalent in our society.

Rural-Urban Social Structure

- The rural-urban social structure received differential developments. Rural society is left with a vast mass of proletariat, including the peasantry, artisans, and working classes. Social groups developed in rural areas: capitalist farmers, rich peasants, middle peasants, marginal peasants, and the landless. The developments of the capitalist mode of production and the emergence of a Green Revolution in rural agriculture have led to differentiation and polarization and widened the gap between the classes. Capitalist farmers can invest in large-scale capital, use modern machinery, and employ adequate hired labor in agriculture. In contrast, marginal peasants do not have this opportunity. On the contrary, failing to survive in the competition, they became poorer and were forced to sell their land.

- Important factors that determine the rural power structure in Bangladesh are economic positions, traditional lineages, land holdings, and proximity to political power or government functionaries. Water lords controlling irrigation can exert enormous influence on the rural power structure. The patron-client relationship is the basis of rural politics.

- Traditional norms and values still dominate rural social structures. Religious values and superstitions tend to uphold the status quo. Social change is slow, piety is emphasized, and internalization of modern values sometimes faces constraints. Among Muslims, Pir, Fakir, and Moulana are highly esteemed for their acclaimed nearness to Allah.

Rural and Urban Social Structure

- The economic status of a rural household is found to be subject to mobility when examined over a long span of time. Different forces result in changes in the financial condition of rural households. Many surplus-producing rural households gradually turned into subsistence households and later deficit households. On the other hand, many deficit households gradually became surplus ones. Market forces, demographic forces, inheritance laws, and household splitting are some of the important factors causing such mobility.
- The rural social stratification in Bangladesh has not always been reflected in the differences in lifestyles, customs, norms, and languages of different classes. Common features in dresses or languages sometimes blur the differences in social status.
- For example, lungi and shirts are dresses worn by rural people irrespective of economic differentiation. However, the very poor often do not use shirts simply because they cannot buy them. Social festivals and ceremonies like Eid ul Fitr and Eid ul Azha are marked by community spirit. The notion of samaj*, or community spirit in the countryside,* reduces the effect of social division.

Rural and Urban Social Structure

- To some extent, the patron-client relationship establishes the relationship between the rich and the poor. Kandahar or lineage status is also taken into account. For example, Syed, Chowdhury, Khandakar, etc., are known as aristocratic or Kandakar Gusti. At the time of the establishment of matrimonial relationships, the rich preferred the rich.
- The differences in material prosperity interpret the differences in social stratification. Lavish living and extravagant expenses indicate one's wealth, status, and power. However, the upper strata are gradually becoming educated, and a social difference between the educated and non-educated is emerging. Gradually, a bhadralok class may also appear in the countryside with a distinct lifestyle based on modern education, etiquette, and culture.

Rural and Urban Social Structure

- Important régional variations mark Urban social structure.
- Dhaka, Chittagong, and Khulna cities incorporate significant industrial and commercial pursuits and vibrant service sectors.
- The cosmopolitan culture and modern values transmitted from the West have come to shape the nature of the urban social structure.
- The urban arena now has modern classes of corporate executives, civil bureaucrats, professionals, intellectuals, artists, industrialists, and businessmen.
- Wealth and education largely determined social status. Traditional factors like lineage and background bear little significance in determining social status.

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